Defeat at the hands of the Afghans in January 1761, in Panipat, Haryana, came as a big blow to their reputation. They would never quite regain their momentum. The scene was set for a war of maps.

THE WAR OF MAPS

As we have already seen, maps were a very important military weapon (and remain so today). One can almost trace the ascendancy of a particular European power by the relative quality of its maps. The Marathas were the only Indian power who developed some cartographic ability. Although their maps are not as rigorous as their European counterparts, they were complemented by an intuitive knowledge of the terrain. Meanwhile, the French and British cartographers replaced the Dutch at the cutting-edge of mapping. At first, it was the French who held the advantage, both on the ground as well as in the quality of their maps. By the early eighteenth century, they had a well-established network of enclaves on the Indian coast. The most important were Pondicherry, just south of Madras (Chennai) and the ancient submerged port of Mahabalipuram. There were smaller outposts like Mahé on the Kerala coast, Yanam on the Andhra coast and Chandannagar on the Hooghly channel of the Ganga, just north of the English settlement at Calcutta. The French also controlled the strategically important island of Mauritius in the middle of the Indian Ocean.

Mirroring the strategic advantage of the French, their maps of India are also superior to those of their rivals. Arguably the best of the French cartographers was D’Anville. He never visited India but appears to have collected the best available information from his Paris home. Cartographic historian Susan Gole has called him the first scientific map-maker. Unlike his predecessors, he strictly focused on geographical accuracy and refrained from eye-catching embellishments. The influence of John Mandeville was finally wearing off. Thus, when D’Anville wanted to correctly locate Satara, the Maratha capital, he asked the Portuguese ambassador to the French court for more information. The Portuguese were fighting the Marathas at that time. D’Anville was told that Satara was in the Ghats and